Balcony Vegetable Gardening: A Beginner's Guide

This short guide was written for the DocuChat sample corpus. It is rendered to a three-page PDF so that answers can cite page numbers.

Choosing a spot

Most fruiting vegetables such as tomatoes, chillies and brinjal need at least six hours of direct sunlight a day. Leafy greens like spinach, lettuce and fenugreek tolerate partial shade and can manage with three to four hours. Before buying any plants, spend one day noting when the sun reaches each corner of your balcony.

Wind is the hidden enemy of high-rise balconies. Strong gusts dry out leaves and snap tall stems, so place tall plants against a wall or railing and use a mesh screen on the windward side.

Containers and soil

Every container must have drainage holes; waterlogged roots rot within days. A tomato plant needs a pot of at least 20 litres, while herbs such as mint and coriander grow well in 3 to 5 litre pots. Grow bags made of fabric are light, cheap and allow roots to breathe.

Do not use plain garden soil in pots because it compacts and drains poorly. A good potting mix is roughly 40 percent cocopeat, 30 percent compost and 30 percent garden soil or perlite.

Watering

Water early in the morning so that leaves dry during the day, which reduces fungal disease. Push a finger two centimetres into the mix: if it feels dry, water slowly until water runs out of the drainage holes.

In peak Indian summer, terracotta pots may need watering twice a day, while plastic pots hold moisture longer. A layer of mulch, such as dry leaves or coconut husk, cuts evaporation noticeably.

Overwatering is a more common beginner mistake than underwatering. Yellowing lower leaves and a sour smell from the soil are typical signs of too much water.

Feeding plants

Container plants exhaust their nutrients quickly. Add a handful of vermicompost to each pot every three weeks during the growing season. For fruiting plants, a liquid feed made by soaking banana peels in water for two days adds potassium, which helps flowering and fruit set.

Pests and problems

Aphids are tiny green or black insects that cluster on new growth. Spray them off with water, or apply a neem oil solution made from 5 ml of neem oil and a few drops of liquid soap in one litre of water, every five days in the evening.

Mealybugs look like white cotton on stems; dab them with a cotton swab dipped in rubbing alcohol. Remove leaves with powdery mildew promptly and improve air circulation between pots.

What to grow first

For a first season, start with plants that forgive mistakes: mint, curry leaf, cherry tomatoes, green chillies and spinach. Microgreens such as mustard and radish can be harvested in about ten days, which makes them a rewarding first project.

Keep a simple notebook of sowing dates, watering and harvests. After one season you will know your balcony's sunlight and microclimate far better than any guide can tell you.